reeds, are abandoned when they suffer from fever, or are harassed by wild beasts, or when the soil ceases to be productive.'[10] So wrote the pioneer ethnographer Dr Edgar Thurston, superintendent of the Madras Museum, in his monumental seven-volume *Castes and Tribes of Southern India*, published in 1909, compiled with the help of his two colleagues L. K. Ananthakrishna Iyer and N. Subramania Iyer, working in Cochin and Travancore respectively.

The Kanikkar tribe's farming practices were rudimentary: 'The Kanikars first clear a patch of forest and set fire to it. The ground is sown with hardly any tillage. When after two or three years the land diminishes in productiveness, they move onto another part of the forest.' This was the classic shifting agriculture known as 'slash-and-burn', practised by tropical and semi-tropical forest-dwellers throughout the world. Although the Kanikkar grew cereals, pulses, tapioca and sweet potatoes, they saw themselves primarily as hunters and foragers: 'The Kanikars wander all over the hills in search of honey. Other occupations are trapping, capturing or killing elephants, tigers or wild pigs, and making wickerwork articles of bamboo or rattan. They are employed by the Government to collect honey, wax, ginger, cardamoms, *dammar* [a resin used for varnish] and elephant tusks.'

Like so many peoples in South and central India now classed as Scheduled Tribes, the Kanikkar considered themselves to be dispossessed, even going so far as to describe themselves as *thankam*, or hereditary landowners. And like many such communities, they were essentially egalitarian. A century ago they were respected by all who came into contact with them, being described as 'straightforward, honest and truthful'. Much the same can be said for their present-day descendants, despite the pressures placed on them and their fast-shrinking